Hercules 3D Prophet 9600 PRO

Kid pro revs up the heat

Hercules, with its reputation for top quality video cards, got everything right for the 9600 PRO. Installation was fairly simple, and the first thing that caught our attention when the test machine was booted up, was the card's fan. There's

a small neon-blue LED under the fan which makes it look like a futuristic gizmo.

The 9600 is based on the RV350 chipset, which is a derivative of the R350 chipset used in the 9800 PRO, and is the first ATI card manufactured using the 0.13 micron fabrication process. The RV350 features four DX9 pixel pipelines and two vertex shaders, which is exactly half of the R350 used in 9800 PRO. The two variants of this core are the 9600 and the 9600 PRO, running at 325/400 (200 MHz DDR) and 400/600 (300 MHz DDR) respectively. ATI therefore expects that the performance to price ratio of the 9600 would make it agreeable to consumers.

Our test bed comprised a Pentium 4 3.2 GHz, Intel D875PBZ motherboard (Canterwood), 512 MB DDR333 RAM, 120 GB Seagate SATA hard drive, Creative Audigy 2 and the Hercules 3D Prophet 9600 PRO. The drivers for the card were the latest Catalyst 3.5 drivers. Installation of the drivers went well without any hitches, and the system was up and running without crashes.

In the tests, the 9600 PRO packed a mean punch. It gave a comfortable 107.2 fps with *Serious Sam SE* at 1024 x 768 x 32. *Quake III Arena* was no different, with 216.2 fps at 1024 x 768 x 32. The most surprising results were in 3DMark2003 tests: this card gave us a whopping score of 3465 with all the eye-candy turned on!

The 9600 PRO is DirectX 9 and OpenGL 2.0 compliant. Fill rate is at a massive 1.6 billion texels per sec with a memory bandwidth of 9.6 GBps—this translates into comfortable, playable framerates at high resolutions with DirectX 9.0 and OpenGL 2.0 games. You also get dual monitor support and an S-Video out with this card for those multi-monitor sessions. It's very important to note that the card will not fit into AGP slots in older motherboards, because it has only a single notch for 1.5 volts.

This card is priced at Rs 16,875, which is much lesser than what the 9800 PRO costs, and with the features this card provides, it is one great buy!

Price: Rs 16,875
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SPECIFICATIONS

256-bit architecture, 400 MHz clock, 0.13 micron fabrication, AGP 8x , 128-bit 600 MHz DDR, 128 MB video RAM, 400 MHz RAMDAC, maximum resolution of 2048 x 1536 at 85 Hz

Hercules 3D Prophet 9600 PRO	A-
Performance	
Features	
Value for money	
Build Quality	

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